

# Home Prices, Rents & Wages in Cabarrus County

## How has housing affordability changed over the past two decades?

Cabarrus County has grown rapidly since the mid-2000s, but that growth has come at a mounting cost for residents seeking housing. Median home values and rents have far outpaced income gains, squeezing household budgets and putting homeownership increasingly out of reach. This brief uses U.S. Census Bureau data to track how these trends have unfolded from 2006 through 2023.

+158%

Median home values since 2006, vs. +73% for household incomes

+121%

Annual rents since 2006, roughly 1.7× faster than wages

4.4×

Price-to-income ratio in 2023, up from 2.9× in 2006

## Housing Costs vs. Wage Growth, 2006–2023

The chart displays three data series from 2006 to 2023, with an index where 2006 = 100. The y-axis ranges from 100 to 250. The x-axis shows years from 2006 to 2022, with data for 2023. A shaded gray area from 2008 to 2010 marks the 'Great Recession'. The blue line (Median Home Value) rises to approximately 255 by 2023. The orange line (Annual Rent) rises to approximately 220. The black line (Median Household Income) rises to approximately 175. All three series show a sharp increase starting around 2012, with a notable dip in 2020.

| Year | Median Home Value (Index) | Annual Rent (Index) | Median Household Income (Index) |
|------|---------------------------|---------------------|---------------------------------|
| 2006 | 100                       | 100                 | 100                             |
| 2008 | 120                       | 110                 | 115                             |
| 2010 | 115                       | 110                 | 100                             |
| 2012 | 115                       | 115                 | 110                             |
| 2014 | 120                       | 125                 | 110                             |
| 2016 | 140                       | 130                 | 130                             |
| 2018 | 155                       | 140                 | 140                             |
| 2020 | 180                       | 160                 | 160                             |
| 2022 | 245                       | 190                 | 160                             |
| 2023 | 255                       | 220                 | 175                             |

Figure 1: Index where 2006 = 100. ACS 1-year estimates were not collected in 2020 (COVID-related disruption).

! Important

**The wage-housing gap.** Between 2006 and 2023, median home values in Cabarrus County outpaced household income growth by **85 percentage points**. That gap widened sharply after 2012 and accelerated further during the post-pandemic housing surge of 2020–2022.

## The Affordability Gap: Home Price-to-Income Ratio

cabarrusdatalab.com Source: U.S. Census Bureau, ACS 1-Year Estimates (2006–2023)

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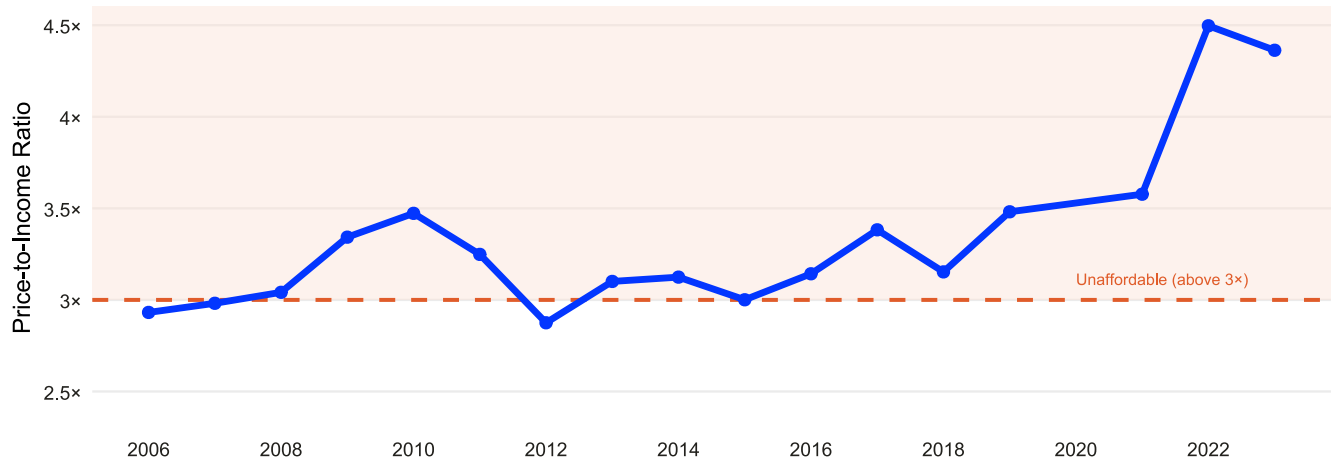


Figure 2: Median home value divided by median household income. Economists traditionally use 3× as the upper boundary of affordability for homeownership.

| Year | Home Value | Annual Rent | Median Income | Price/Income |
|------|------------|-------------|---------------|--------------|
| 2006 | \$145,000  | \$8,000     | \$50,000      | 2.9×         |
| 2010 | \$169,000  | \$8,900     | \$49,000      | 3.5×         |
| 2015 | \$171,000  | \$10,300    | \$57,000      | 3×           |
| 2019 | \$252,000  | \$11,800    | \$72,000      | 3.5×         |
| 2023 | \$374,000  | \$17,800    | \$86,000      | 4.4×         |

#### Note

**About this brief.** Data are drawn from the U.S. Census Bureau's American Community Survey (ACS), 1-year estimates, for Cabarrus County, NC. Variables: B25077 (median owner-occupied home value), B25064 (median gross rent), B19013 (median household income). ACS 1-year estimates were not released for 2020. All values are nominal and not adjusted for inflation. The 3× price-to-income threshold follows the convention used by the National Association of Realtors and urban economists.